

Orientalism's greatest villains shrink before the jaundiced gaze of Mehta's narrators. Their India, as though reflected in a distorting mirror, is in turns naïve, in turns a freak show, full of veiled contempt. In *Ten Thousand Years*, there are street sellers with fists that open like "dirty lilies", deranged women who vigorously massage their clitorises in the middle of a busy street in broad daylight and, invariably, boys—lots of boys; boys, with "flat torsos [glistening] with sweat, reflecting sunlight like a mirror," who are usually available for sex.

In *Floating*, the narrator and his boyfriend, Darnell, are harassed by Carlone, a young shop owner who forcefully offers the narrator his brothers for a price; they befriend Rajesh whose "clothes make me think he is one of us;" but Rajesh also turns out to be a prostitute. It's as the narrator's Indian mother warns from the safety of suburban America: "Desperate people will do desperate things." But neither India's desperation nor the old dadas and nanis Mehta troops out—and, who are so often a source of shame to his various narrators—are dealt with seriously. They form no more than the background to a tense foreground with Jeremy, with Thomas, with whoever...Most of the time you'd

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rather eat the carpet than read about another one of these doomed relationships.

And sexuality is not the only thing to be inverted in Mehta's stories. Writing virtues, like simplicity, economy, the art of saying more by saying less, are also turned on their head, and used instead to conceal the failings of the writing. The title story, for instance, ends with the sentence: "I reach for a box of spaghetti and set a pot of water on the stove to boil." The reader is meant to feel that something profound has occurred, but when he thinks back to the story, with its slack narrative and its confused impulses, he can't imagine what it might be.

In the end, these stories matter very little. They must serve only as a warning of what not to do; of how content and form are inextricably linked; and of how one's material cannot just be passed through a creative writing filter. Or perhaps it can, but in America then, where the audience consumes it in the same way as they might one night decide to eat Afghan food, the next Ethiopian. In India, now with so many real things to consider, a book like this constitutes the worst kind of decadence.

(Aatish Taseer is the author of the novel *The Temple-Goers*.)

Thunder of the East

The political and social cost of the golden future of India and China

| By Amitabh Mattoo |



The rise of China, the emergence of India and the decline of American hegemony is a story that has been told, ad nauseum. Nearly a decade ago, in the autumn of 2003, Goldman Sachs, the global investment banking and securities firm (currently under clout for capitalising on the collapse of the US housing market) produced a report that made even the otherwise somnolent civil servants of Raisina Hill wake up. In an act of extraordinary crystal gazing, the investment firm declared that the combined GDP of Brazil, Russia, India and China (BRIC) by 2039 would exceed that of the G-6 (the US, the UK, France, Germany, Italy and Japan). By 2050, the report predicted, China would have overtaken the American economy while India's GDP would be 80 per cent of the US's.

The BRIC report has since spawned dozens of books, reports and articles: agreeing, disagreeing or merely taking the argument forward in several different directions. Two years later, the National Intelligence Council (NIC), a well-respected American body that usually makes cautious forecasts, too seemed to reinforce the BRIC study. Our very own Jairam Ramesh is believed to have coined the portmanteau term Chindia to capsule the energy that was likely to be released by these two Asian giants. Given this proliferation of literature, is there anything new then to be said about China and India that has not already been said?

Prem Shankar Jha is a sceptic, a pessimist, and not given—on most issues—to swim with the tide. In this book, Jha's argument is simple and reasonable. He argues that all projections about the golden future that awaits China and India are based merely on economic trends, while neglecting the societal and political transitions and transformations that are concurrently taking place. And these could well undermine the macro economic strides that we are witnessing. As he concludes, projections by Sachs or the NIC, "fail to account that the two countries are not simply undergoing economic growth, but undergoing a transformation into capitalist state. This is not only an economic but also a political change, pregnant with conflict between winners and losers from the transformation. The future will not be assured for either country until it succeeds in harmonizing their interests."